

■ By Devayani Shahane

On a chilly November morning, the sun rays filter into the Ramamani Iyengar Memorial Yoga Institute (RIMYI) Hall in Pune. Yogacharya Bellur Krishnamachar Sundaraja Iyengar is in the midst of his five-hour daily practice. While practising, his watchful eye spots an erring student and he is quick to correct her. The 89-year-old Gururji has given 15,000 demonstrations, and is largely responsible for the 30 million yoga practitioners worldwide. The credit for starting RIMYI, which began in 1975 and is revered as the mecca of yoga learners, goes to him.

Born in 1918 into a large and poor family, in Bellur, Karnataka, Iyengar often suffered from malaria, typhoid and tuberculosis in his childhood. In 1934, his brother-in-law and yoga teacher Guru Sri T.

Krishnamacharya advised him to pursue yoga. "My body was stiff and yoga did not ignite my interest," he says. He, however, continued to travel with his guru to give demonstrations in different parts of the country. On one such tour, surgeon V.B. Gokhale expressed the need for yoga centres in Pune and a young Iyengar was deputed for the task. Thus began a new chapter in his life. The period between 1935 and 1937 was full of struggle and strife.

"In 1946, God gave me a grain and said that all my worries would come to an end," says Iyengar. This divine intervention changed his life. The turning point came in 1954 when violin maestro Yehudi Menuhin, who was searching for a master, heard of Iyengar. A meeting was set up in which Menuhin quizzed him about this ancient form of exercise. "I told him yoga cannot be explained, it has to be done," says Iyengar. A 45-minute demonstration followed which left Menuhin spell-bound. The flood-gates to the western world opened. Iyengar travelled to England and France, and taught top musicians. His disciples range from the late Jayaprakash Narayan and J. Krishnamurthi to Sachin Tendulkar and Rahul Dravid. His book *Light on Yoga*, considered the Bible of yoga was translated into 18 Indian and foreign languages.

Iyengar says he decided to spread this neglected form of body and soul meditation because he wanted to bring credit to the art. Today his Pune institute has about 1,600 to 1,800 students and his work is taken forth by his students, which include his son Prashant and daughter Geeta in India and in more than 300 centres in countries like the US, Argentina, Bermuda, Chile, China, Switzerland and Spain. His international celebrity followers range from Donna Karan to Christy Turlington. "I changed the style of presentation and brought elegance, grace and rhythm in yoga. This attracted people," he says.

There are numerous opinions on what yoga seeks to achieve. It usually involves some kind of union, both spiritual and mental. Many schools of thought consider it the ultimate way to achieve *moksha* or salvation. But for Iyengar, yoga is the means to unite the soul with the universal spirit. Perhaps, this is why he has been instrumental in spreading yoga across the globe, with versions ranging from Bikram Choudhury's hatha yoga to Swami Ramdev's telly pranayam. ■

DHIRENDRA BRAHMACHARI, yogi, 1980

"The country needs discipline, and yoga is the only way to infuse it among our people."

